

Document 7: Conjunctivitis (Pink Eye)

Metadata

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Definition of Conjunctivitis

Conjunctivitis is an inflammation or infection of the transparent membrane (conjunctiva) that lines the eyelid and covers the white part of the eyeball. It can be caused by viruses, bacteria, or allergies. Viral and bacterial forms are highly contagious.

Symptoms of Conjunctivitis

Symptoms can affect one or both eyes and typically include:

- Redness in the white of the eye or inner eyelid
- A gritty feeling or itchiness in the eye
- A discharge that forms a crust during the night, which may prevent the eye from opening in the morning
- Increased tearing and mild sensitivity to light

Treatment and Management for Conjunctivitis

Treatment depends heavily on the underlying cause:

- **Viral:** Typically runs its course in 1 to 2 weeks without medical treatment. Cold compresses and artificial tears can soothe symptoms.
- **Bacterial:** Requires a prescription for antibiotic eye drops or ointments.
- **Allergic:** Treated with allergy medications (antihistamines) in the form of eye drops or pills.
- **Hygiene:** Strict handwashing and avoiding sharing towels or pillowcases are critical to prevent spreading the infection.

When to Seek Medical Attention for Conjunctivitis

A patient should consult an eye care specialist or doctor if they experience:

- Moderate to severe pain in the eye(s).
- Intense sensitivity to light (photophobia) or blurred vision that does not improve when discharge is wiped away.
- Symptoms that worsen or do not improve after 24 hours of starting antibiotics.